Past Problems

for the International Mathematical Olympiad

Jungwoo Kim
Department of Mathematics
Pohang University of Science and Technology

Contents

Part I. Competition Problems **1**
2020 1
2021 2
2022 3
2023 3
2024 4
2025 5
2026 6

Part I. Competition Problems

Problem 2020.1. Consider the convex quadrilateral $ABCD$. The point P is in the interior of $ABCD$. The following ratio equalities hold:

$$\angle PAD : \angle PBA : \angle DPA = 1 : 2 : 3 = \angle CBP : \angle BAP : \angle BPC.$$

Prove that the following three lines meet in a point: the internal bisectors of angles $\angle ADP$ and $\angle PCB$ and the perpendicular bisector of segment AB.

Problem 2020.2. The real numbers a, b, c, d are such that $a \geq b \geq c \geq d > 0$ and $a+b+c+d = 1$. Prove that

$$(a + 2b + 3c + 4d)a^a b^b c^c d^d < 1.$$

Problem 2020.3. There are $4n$ pebbles of weights $1, 2, 3, \ldots, 4n$. Each pebble is coloured in one of n colours and there are four pebbles of each colour. Show that we can arrange the pebbles into two piles so that the following two conditions are both satisfied:

- The total weights of both piles are the same.
- Each pile contains two pebbles of each colour.

Problem 2020.4. There is an integer $n > 1$. There are n^2 stations on a slope of a mountain, all at different altitudes. Each of two cable car companies, A and B, operates k cable cars; each cable car provides a transfer from one of the stations to a higher one (with no intermediate stops). The k cable cars of A have k different starting points and k different finishing points, and a cable car which starts higher also finishes higher. The same conditions hold for B. We say that two stations are *linked* by a company if one can start from the lower station and reach the

higher one by using one or more cars of that company (no other movements between stations are allowed).

Determine the smallest positive integer k for which one can guarantee that there are two stations that are linked by both companies.

Problem 2020.5. A deck of $n > 1$ cards is given. A positive integer is written on each card. The deck has the property that the arithmetic mean of the numbers on each pair of cards is also the geometric mean of the numbers on some collection of one or more cards.

For which n does it follow that the numbers on the cards are all equal?

Problem 2020.6. Prove that there exists a positive constant c such that the following statement is true:

Consider an integer $n > 1$, and a set S of n points in the plane such that the distance between any two different points in S is at least 1. It follows that there is a line ℓ separating S such that the distance from any point of S to ℓ is at least $cn^{-1/3}$.

(A line ℓ *separates* a set of points S if some segment joining two points in S crosses ℓ.)

Problem 2021.1. Let $n \geq 100$ be an integer. Ivan writes the numbers $n, n+1, \ldots, 2n$ each on different cards. He then shuffles these $n+1$ cards, and divides them into two piles. Prove that at least one of the piles contains two cards such that the sum of their numbers is a perfect square.

Problem 2021.2. Show that the inequality

$$\sum_{i=1}^{n}\sum_{j=1}^{n}\sqrt{|x_i - x_j|} \leq \sum_{i=1}^{n}\sum_{j=1}^{n}\sqrt{|x_i + x_j|}$$

holds for all real numbers $x_1, \ldots, x_n$.

Problem 2021.3. Let D be an interior point of the acute triangle ABC with $AB > AC$ so that $\angle DAB = \angle CAD$. The point E on the segment AC satisfies $\angle ADE = \angle BCD$, the point F on the segment AB satisfies $\angle FDA = \angle DBC$, and the point X on the line AC satisfies $CX = BX$. Let O_1 and O_2 be the circumcentres of the triangles ADC and EXD, respectively. Prove that the lines BC, EF, and O_1O_2 are concurrent.

Problem 2021.4. Let Γ be a circle with centre I, and $ABCD$ a convex quadrilateral such that each of the segments AB, BC, CD and DA is tangent to Γ. Let Ω be the circumcircle of the triangle AIC. The extension of BA beyond A meets Ω at X, and the extension of BC beyond C meets Ω at Z. The extensions of AD and CD beyond D meet Ω at Y and T, respectively. Prove that

$$AD + DT + TX + XA = CD + DY + YZ + ZC.$$

Problem 2021.5. Two squirrels, Bushy and Jumpy, have collected 2021 walnuts for the winter. Jumpy numbers the walnuts from 1 through 2021, and digs 2021 little holes in a circular pattern in the ground around their favourite tree. The next morning Jumpy notices that Bushy had placed one walnut into each hole, but had paid no attention to the numbering. Unhappy, Jumpy decides to reorder the walnuts by performing a sequence of 2021 moves. In the k-th move, Jumpy swaps the positions of the two walnuts adjacent to walnut k.

Prove that there exists a value of k such that, on the k-th move, Jumpy swaps some walnuts a and b such that $a < k < b$.

Problem 2021.6. Let $m \geq 2$ be an integer, A be a finite set of (not necessarily positive) integers, and $B_1, B_2, B_3, \ldots, B_m$ be subsets of A. Assume that for each $k = 1, 2, \ldots, m$ the sum of the elements of B_k is m^k. Prove that A contains at least $m/2$ elements.

Problem 2022.1. The Bank of Oslo issues two types of coin: aluminium (denoted A) and bronze (denoted B). Marianne has n aluminium coins and n bronze coins, arranged in a row in some arbitrary initial order. A *chain* is any subsequence of consecutive coins of the same type. Given a fixed positive integer $k \leq 2n$, Marianne repeatedly performs the following operation: she identifies the longest chain containing the k-th coin from the left, and moves all coins in that chain to the left end of the row. For example, if $n = 4$ and $k = 4$, the process starting from the ordering $AABBBABA$ would be

$$AAB\underline{B}BABA \to BBB\underline{A}AABA \to AAA\underline{B}BBBA$$
$$\to BBB\underline{B}AAAA \to BBB\underline{B}AAAA \to \cdots .$$

Find all pairs (n, k) with $1 \leq k \leq 2n$ such that for every initial ordering, at some moment during the process, the leftmost n coins will all be of the same type.

Problem 2022.2. Find all functions $f\colon \mathbb{R}_{>0} \to \mathbb{R}_{>0}$ such that for each $x \in \mathbb{R}_{>0}$, there is exactly one $y \in \mathbb{R}_{>0}$ satisfying

$$xf(y) + yf(x) \leq 2.$$

Problem 2022.3. Let k be a positive integer and let S be a finite set of odd prime numbers. Prove that there is at most one way (up to rotation and reflection) to place the elements of S around a circle such that the product of any two neighbours is of the form $x^2 + x + k$ for some positive integer x.

Problem 2022.4. Let $ABCDE$ be a convex pentagon such that $BC = DE$. Assume that there is a point T inside $ABCDE$ with $TB = TD$, $TC = TE$ and $\angle ABT = \angle TEA$. Let line AB intersect lines CD and CT at points P and Q, respectively. Assume that the points P, B, A, Q occur on their line in that order. Let line AE intersect lines CD and DT at points R and S, respectively. Assume that the points R, E, A, S occur on their line in that order. Prove that the points P, S, Q, R lie on a circle.

Problem 2022.5. Find all triples (a, b, p) of positive integers with p prime and

$$a^p = b! + p.$$

Problem 2022.6. Let n be a positive integer. A *Nordic square* is an $n \times n$ board containing all the integers from 1 to n^2 so that each cell contains exactly one number. Two different cells are considered adjacent if they share a common side. Every cell that is adjacent only to cells containing larger numbers is called a *valley*. An *uphill path* is a sequence of one or more cells such that:

(i) the first cell in the sequence is a valley,
(ii) each subsequent cell in the sequence is adjacent to the previous cell, and
(iii) the numbers written in the cells in the sequence are in increasing order.

Find, as a function of n, the smallest possible total number of uphill paths in a Nordic square.

Problem 2023.1. Determine all composite integers $n > 1$ that satisfy the following property: if $d_1, d_2, \ldots, d_k$ are all the positive divisors of n with $1 = d_1 < d_2 < \cdots < d_k = n$, then d_i divides $d_{i+1} + d_{i+2}$ for every $1 \leq i \leq k-2$.

Problem 2023.2. Let ABC be an acute-angled triangle with $AB < AC$. Let Ω be the circumcircle of ABC. Let S be the midpoint of the arc CB of Ω containing A. The perpendicular from A to BC meets BS at D and meets Ω again at $E \neq A$. The line through D parallel to BC meets line BE at L. Denote the circumcircle of triangle BDL by ω. Let ω meet Ω again at $P \neq B$.

Prove that the line tangent to ω at P meets line BS on the internal angle bisector of $\angle BAC$.

Problem 2023.3. For each integer $k \geq 2$, determine all infinite sequences of positive integers $a_1, a_2, \ldots$ for which there exists a polynomial P of the form $P(x) = x^k + c_{k-1}x^{k-1} + \cdots + c_1 x + c_0$, where $c_0, c_1, \ldots, c_{k-1}$ are non-negative integers, such that

$$P(a_n) = a_{n+1}a_{n+2}\cdots a_{n+k}$$

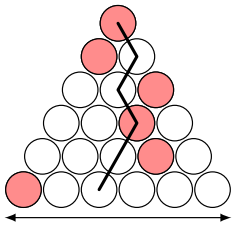
for every integer $n \geq 1$.

Problem 2023.4. Let $x_1, x_2, \ldots, x_{2023}$ be pairwise different positive real numbers such that

$$a_n = \sqrt{(x_1 + x_2 + \cdots + x_n)\left(\frac{1}{x_1} + \frac{1}{x_2} + \cdots + \frac{1}{x_n}\right)}$$

is an integer for every $n = 1, 2, \ldots, 2023$. Prove that $a_{2023} \geq 3034$.

Problem 2023.5. Let n be a positive integer. A *Japanese triangle* consists of $1 + 2 + \cdots + n$ circles arranged in an equilateral triangular shape such that for each $i = 1, 2, \ldots, n$, the i-th row contains exactly i circles, exactly one of which is coloured red. A *ninja path* in a Japanese triangle is a sequence of n circles obtained by starting in the top row, then repeatedly going from a circle to one of the two circles immediately below it and finishing in the bottom row. Here is an example of a Japanese triangle with $n = 6$, along with a ninja path in that triangle containing two red circles.



In terms of n, find the greatest k such that in each Japanese triangle there is a ninja path containing at least k red circles.

Problem 2023.6. Let ABC be an equilateral triangle. Let A_1, B_1, C_1 be interior points of ABC such that $BA_1 = A_1C$, $CB_1 = B_1A$, $AC_1 = C_1B$, and

$$\angle BA_1C + \angle CB_1A + \angle AC_1B = 480^\circ.$$

Let BC_1 and CB_1 meet at A_2, let CA_1 and AC_1 meet at B_2, and let AB_1 and BA_1 meet at C_2. Prove that if triangle $A_1B_1C_1$ is scalene, then the three circumcircles of triangles AA_1A_2, BB_1B_2 and CC_1C_2 all pass through two common points.

Problem 2024.1. Determine all real numbers α such that, for every positive integer n, the integer

$$\lfloor \alpha \rfloor + \lfloor 2\alpha \rfloor + \cdots + \lfloor n\alpha \rfloor$$

is a multiple of n.

Problem 2024.2. Determine all pairs (a, b) of positive integers for which there exist positive integers g and N such that

$$\gcd(a^n + b, b^n + a) = g$$

holds for all integers $n \geq N$.

Problem 2024.3. Let $a_1, a_2, a_3, \ldots$ be an infinite sequence of positive integers, and let N be a positive integer. Suppose that, for each $n > N$, a_n is equal to the number of times a_{n-1} appears in the list $a_1, a_2, \ldots, a_{n-1}$.

Prove that at least one of the sequences $a_1, a_3, a_5, \ldots$ and $a_2, a_4, a_6, \ldots$ is eventually periodic.

(An infinite sequence $b_1, b_2, b_3, \ldots$ is *eventually periodic* if there exist positive integers p and M such that $b_{m+p} = b_m$ for all $m \geq M$.)

Problem 2024.4. Let ABC be a triangle with $AB < AC < BC$. Let the incentre and incircle of triangle ABC be I and ω, respectively. Let X be the point on line BC different from C such that the line through X parallel to AC is tangent to ω. Similarly, let Y be the point on line BC different from B such that the line through Y parallel to AB is tangent to ω. Let AI intersect the circumcircle of triangle ABC again at $P \neq A$. Let K and L be the midpoints of AC and AB, respectively.

Prove that $\angle KIL + \angle YPX = 180^\circ$.

Problem 2024.5. Turbo the snail plays a game on a board with 2024 rows and 2023 columns. There are hidden monsters in 2022 of the cells. Initially, Turbo does not know where any of the monsters are, but he knows that there is exactly one monster in each row except the first row and the last row, and that each column contains at most one monster.

Turbo makes a series of attempts to go from the first row to the last row. On each attempt, he chooses to start on any cell in the first row, then repeatedly moves to an adjacent cell sharing a common side. (He is allowed to return to a previously visited cell.) If he reaches a cell with a monster, his attempt ends and he is transported back to the first row to start a new attempt. The monsters do not move, and Turbo remembers whether or not each cell he has visited contains a monster. If he reaches any cell in the last row, his attempt ends and the game is over.

Determine the minimum value of n for which Turbo has a strategy that guarantees reaching the last row on the n-th attempt or earlier, regardless of the locations of the monsters.

Problem 2024.6. A function $f\colon \mathbb{Q} \to \mathbb{Q}$ is called *aquaesulian* if the following property holds: for every $x, y \in \mathbb{Q}$,

$$f(x + f(y)) = f(x) + y \qquad \text{or} \qquad f(f(x) + y) = x + f(y).$$

Show that there exists an integer c such that for any aquaesulian function f there are at most c different rational numbers of the form $f(r) + f(-r)$ for some rational number r, and find the smallest possible value of c.

Problem 2025.1. A line in the plane is called *sunny* if it is not parallel to any of the x-axis, the y-axis, and the line $x + y = 0$.

Let $n \geq 3$ be a given integer. Determine all nonnegative integers k such that there exist n distinct lines in the plane satisfying both of the following:

- for all positive integers a and b with $a+b \leq n+1$, the point (a, b) is on at least one of the lines; and
- exactly k of the n lines are sunny.

Problem 2025.2. Let Ω and Γ be circles with centres M and N, respectively, such that the radius of Ω is less than the radius of Γ. Suppose circles Ω and Γ intersect at two distinct points A and B. Line MN intersects Ω at C and Γ at D, such that points C, M, N and D lie on the line in that order. Let P be the circumcentre of triangle ACD. Line AP intersects Ω again at $E \neq A$. Line AP intersects Γ again at $F \neq A$. Let H be the orthocentre of triangle PMN.

Prove that the line through H parallel to AP is tangent to the circumcircle of triangle BEF.

Problem 2025.3. A function $f\colon \mathbb{N} \to \mathbb{N}$ is said to be *bonza* if

$$f(a) \mid b^a - f(b)^{f(a)}$$

for all positive integers a and b.

Determine the smallest real constant c such that $f(n) \leq cn$ for all bonza functions f and all positive integers n.

Problem 2025.4. A *proper divisor* of a positive integer N is a positive divisor of N other than N itself.

The infinite sequence $a_1, a_2, \ldots$ consists of positive integers, each of which has at least three proper divisors. For each $n \geq 1$, the integer a_{n+1} is the sum of the three largest proper divisors of a_n.

Determine all possible values of a_1.

Problem 2025.5. Alice and Bazza are playing the *inekoalaty game*, a two-player game whose rules depend on a positive real number λ which is known to both players. On the n-th turn of the game (starting with $n = 1$) the following happens:

- If n is odd, Alice chooses a nonnegative real number x_n such that
$$x_1 + x_2 + \cdots + x_n \leq \lambda n.$$
- If n is even, Bazza chooses a nonnegative real number x_n such that
$$x_1^2 + x_2^2 + \cdots + x_n^2 \leq n.$$

If a player cannot choose a suitable number x_n, the game ends and the other player wins. If the game goes on forever, neither player wins. All chosen numbers are known to both players.

Determine all values of λ for which Alice has a winning strategy and all those for which Bazza has a winning strategy.

Problem 2025.6. Consider a 2025×2025 grid of unit squares. Matilda wishes to place on the grid some rectangular tiles, possibly of different sizes, such that each side of every tile lies on a grid line and every unit square is covered by at most one tile.

Determine the minimum number of tiles Matilda needs to place so that each row and each column of the grid has exactly one unit square that is not covered by any tile.

Problem 2026.1. There are 2026 integers greater than 1 written on a blackboard, not necessarily different. In a move, Confucius chooses two integers $m > 1$ and $n > 1$ from different places on the blackboard and replaces these two integers with

$$\gcd(m, n) \qquad \text{and} \qquad \frac{\operatorname{lcm}(m, n)}{\gcd(m, n)}.$$

He continues to make moves while it is possible to do so.

(a) Prove that, regardless of the choices of Confucius, after finitely many moves, exactly one integer M on the blackboard is greater than 1.

(b) Prove that the value of M does not depend on the choices of Confucius.

Problem 2026.2. Let ABC be a triangle and let points M and N be the midpoints of sides AB and AC, respectively. Let points K and L be chosen strictly inside triangles BMC and BNC, respectively, such that K lies strictly inside triangle ABL and L lies strictly inside triangle AKC. Suppose that

$$\angle KBA = \angle ACL, \qquad \angle LBK = \angle LNC, \qquad \angle LCK = \angle BMK.$$

Let O be the circumcentre of triangle AKL. Prove that $OM = ON$.

Problem 2026.3. Let n be a positive integer. Liu Bang and Xiang Yu have a stick of length 1 and want to divide it between themselves. Liu marks at most n points on the stick, and then Xiang marks at most n points on the stick. The marked points are distinct. Then, the stick is cut at all marked points, creating a number of pieces. Afterwards, they take turns claiming any unclaimed piece of the stick, with Liu going first. Each player's goal is to maximise the total length of their own pieces.

For each n, determine the largest value c such that Liu may guarantee a total length of at least c, regardless of Xiang's play.

Problem 2026.4. Shan-Yu and Mulan are playing a game. Let θ be an angle with $0^\circ < \theta < 180^\circ$ known to both players. Initially, Shan-Yu makes a paper triangle $\mathcal{T}$ with measurements of his choice. Then, they repeatedly perform the following steps:

- If $\mathcal{T}$ has at least one angle measuring exactly θ, then the game stops and Mulan wins.
- Otherwise, Mulan chooses a point P on the perimeter of $\mathcal{T}$, different from its three vertices. She then makes a straight cut from P to the opposite vertex of $\mathcal{T}$, splitting it into two triangles.
- Shan-Yu discards one of the two triangles. The remaining triangle becomes the new $\mathcal{T}$.

For which real values of θ can Mulan guarantee her victory in finitely many steps, no matter how Shan-Yu plays?

Problem 2026.5. Determine all functions $f\colon \mathbb{R}_{>0} \to \mathbb{R}_{>0}$ such that

$$\sqrt{\frac{x^2 + f(y)^2}{2}} \geq \frac{f(x) + y}{2} \geq \sqrt{xf(y)}$$

for every $x, y \in \mathbb{R}_{>0}$.

Problem 2026.6. Let $a_1, a_2, a_3, \ldots$ be an infinite sequence of positive integers greater than 1. Suppose that for all positive integers n, the number a_{n+1} is the smallest positive integer greater than a_n such that $\gcd(a_{n+1}, a_i) > 1$ for every $i = 1, 2, \ldots, n$. Prove that there exist positive integers T and L such that

$$a_{n+T} = a_n + L$$

for every positive integer n.